

HEALTHCARE

Nursing a CURE

A paradigm shift is at work. Powered by technology, funded by private corporates and driven by new-age consumers, healthcare has taken a giant leap forward

■ By Damayanti Datta

The rich scent of orange blossoms wafts around the lobby. The cool modern décor enhances that fragrant elegance. No. Not a fancy hotel, but a brand new “boutique” hospital for women in the Capital that believes in keeping up with the times and pampering the consumer. Here, would-be mothers sleep on remote-controlled beds, bathe in jacuzzis, get monitored on 4D, real-time, ultrasound imaging systems, welcome newborns in private birthing suites along with family members, and babies are put to sleep on music that matches their heart-

beats. So what if newness has its price? Happy patients are paying up and leaving happy.

Step back in time and pose a contrast: life expectancy has shot up in India, from 23 at the turn of the 20th century to 65 years, while death rates have come down—from 25 per thousand to eight. We used to die of dreaded infections in circa 1900. Not anymore. We will die of lifestyle excesses—of the way we live—in the future, say medics. What has turned the century-old image of India as the hotbed of inadequate, unsanitary healthcare, of stick-thin poverty and malaria? What's attracting

Photograph by ISHAN TANKHA; Location courtesy: LA FEMME CLINIC, Delhi

GOOD HEALTH: A patient at a birthing clinic in Delhi

